

Poker Legend

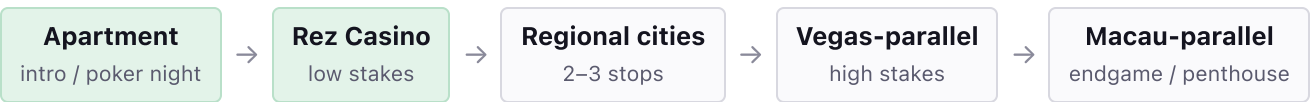
Build roadmap · status as of 29 September 2026

GENRE	PLATFORMS	STACK	VARIANT
Story-driven poker RPG	Browser + iPhone (Capacitor)	Vite · React · TS · PixiJS	Texas Hold'em only
REPO	~/projects/poker-legend		

The concept

LeafGreen-style top-down overworld exploration between story beats, dropping into a fully-simulated, realistic-odds poker engine whenever the player sits down at a table. The player rises from a broke twenty-something at a friend's home game to a poker legend across an escalating ladder of casino cities — risking real debt along the way.

Location ladder



MVP phases

- DONE

1 · Scaffold
Vite + React + TypeScript project, PixiJS wired into a full-viewport canvas, living design docs (GDD + tech design) established as the source of truth.
- DONE

2 · Apartment scene
Walkable room with grid-locked LeafGreen-style movement, tile collision, camera follow, and an NPC (Marcus) whose dialogue triggers the poker night. Later refactored into a reusable overworld component.
- DONE

3 · Poker engine core
Real 52-card deck and shuffling, 5- and 7-card hand evaluation, multi-way side pots, and a full betting-round state machine (blinds, all-ins, street advancement, showdown). AI decisions use Monte Carlo equity estimation — the same technique real equity calculators use — with skill-tiered noise and aggression.
- DONE

4 · Poker night loop
Playable three-handed freezeout against Marcus and Dana. Busting restarts the night from the top; winning all the chips ends the scene and banks the winnings.
- DONE

5 · Bus → local casino
Bus transition carries winnings into a cash wallet. Casino lobby overworld with a Pit Boss (leads to the table) plus ambient slot machines and a craps table. The low-stakes table is a true cash game — fixed buy-in, AI auto-rebuy, human rebuy or leave-and-cash-out.

IN
PROGRESS

6 · Tells & table depth

Opponents give off readable physical cues that correlate with hand strength. Frequency and reliability both scale down with opponent skill, so sharp players give away almost nothing and occasionally give false reads. Currently being built.

IN
PROGRESS

7 · Economy & persistence

Cash tracking and buy-ins are in. Checkpoint saving (surviving a page reload, tied to location transitions per the design) is being added now. A first shop still to come.

Beyond the MVP

PLANNED

8 · Mid-tier cities

Two to three regional casino cities with their own maps, restaurants, clubs, shops (clothes, vehicles) and small side missions — giving the stakes ramp room to breathe.

PLANNED

9 · Sponsors, debt & collectors

NPCs who spot your skill and stake you into bigger private games. Losing staked money creates debt with a deadline; miss it and collectors hunt you — get caught before reaching a new location and you roll back to your last checkpoint.

PLANNED

10 · Mentor & whales

A mentor NPC teaching real, established poker strategy, and the recurring whale archetype — big money, bad play, obvious tells, wide unpredictable ranges.

PLANNED

11 · Vegas-parallel

Second-to-final location. High buy-ins, genuinely strong AI, near-imperceptible tells, and the first serious heads-up opportunities.

PLANNED

12 · Macau-parallel & endgame

Final location and the climactic heads-up match that decides whether you earn the penthouse ending — after which the game opens up into a free-play state.

How this is being built

- **Engine before UI.** The poker engine is plain TypeScript with no React or rendering dependencies, so its correctness can be tested headlessly and trusted before anything is built on top of it.
- **Fuzz testing over spot checks.** Full AI-vs-AI games run across many random seeds, asserting chip conservation after every single action — not just at hand boundaries.
- **Real browser verification.** Each UI phase is driven end-to-end with Playwright before being called done.
- **Living docs.** The design doc and tech design in the repo stay current, so each build request can reference them instead of restating context.

Why the browser testing matters

Phase 4 shipped three real bugs that the unit suite could not see: a stale pot display, a React StrictMode double-invoke that silently ate a blind round's worth of chips on the very first hand, and an effect dependency that could stall the AI's turn entirely. All three only surfaced when the actual app was driven in a real browser.

Open design questions

- Exact number of mid-tier cities — two or three (leaning three for a smoother stakes ramp).
- How deep the non-poker casino games go; slots and craps are ambient flavor for now.
- Audio direction — not yet specified.
- Character customization depth: appearance only, or stat-like traits?